

irritating to view. Even if your site has only text, try and make the text layout look good. Can you imagine yourself reading this book if it didn't have a picture or paragraph breaks to lend visual relief? The same holds true for your site.

You should never substitute text with graphics, such as making an animated GIF image with changing text. Doing this only increases the size of a page, and also takes away people's ability to resize the text on the page according to their needs. It also almost always results in a low-resolution image that shows very poor quality text.

A good rule of thumb is the ratio of 80:20—80 per cent text to 20 per cent images. This means that when you look at the pages you design, no more than 20 per cent of the screen area should be images.

You also need to remember that Web sites have depth, and there's no reason to try and cram everything you offer into your home page. Divide up your content into little piles, study your existing as well as target audiences, and then tag your content in decreasing order of importance or interest to this audience. The top 50 per cent of your content should be easily accessible from your home page, and the rest can either be distributed lower down on your home page or stored in lower levels (different pages) of your site.

Navigation

Very often, you come across sites that lead you to a page best described as a virtual dead-end. Somehow, visitors might get stuck at a place, and have no clue as to how they got there. This usually results in a visitor clicking on the little [X] on the top right corner, banishing your site from their screen forever! The entire reason for taking pains to design sites is to avoid this from ever happening... yet it does!

So what causes this problem? Simple. Bad design!